

SWIFTS JOURNEY

Introduction:

The Sun was shining, and the morning breeze was softly swaying my hair. My grandmother's white hair was shining like silver under the sun while she was sitting next to me, on the flat rooftop of our new home. As I felt the warmth of the cup of tea in my hands, I looked at the sky, observing swifts winging their way south in scattered V-shaped flocks. "Wow! Grandma, look at those birds!" I pointed at them with excitement. She looked at them and smiled.

"I wonder where they are going," I murmured, lost in thought.

"Just like us, they migrate to survive and find a safe home where they can feed themselves and their children. The difference is, they are able to return home after an exact time interval, but we are not," my grandma said as she followed the birds' movements with her tired, sad eyes. That was when I thought of a poetic quote by Banafsheh Taherian that I want to share here:

No migrant conjugates the verb "to migrate" in the same way.

Each left their homeland for a different hope.

No one abandons their home, even a house floating on water, so easily or without a reason. But, each person's reason for leaving their home is unique. However, after migration, we all conjugate our endless, overwhelming longings in the same way.

Every time we mount that great iron horse, ***we do not know whether we are going home or leaving it.***

Khana (Home)

Winter 1999

The sky was heavy with thick, gray clouds mingling with the fog, creating a veil of gray that covered both sky and ground. I couldn't feel my feet, as I was stepping into the snowy arid plain. My stomach was growling loudly and my body was trembling from the cold. Apparently my short black coat could not endure the freezing cold that seemed to penetrate into my bone marrow. I paused for a moment to warm my hands, which had become bluish from the chill, by rubbing together while gently breathing on them. Visibility was limited as the fog swirled around making the home appear even more distant and dreamlike. The village seems quieter than ever now, unlike the night I left with my parents and my six little brothers and sisters. That night, the gunfire echoed in the air, but now the fight was over, at least in our village. The Taliban has taken control of it. I had promised my mom that I wouldn't go back, that I would stay with them in the valley, where everyone was safe from gunshots and war. But despite everything I was just a 12-year-old boy who wanted to go home. I wanted to take care of our two cows and sheep, the only things we had left to get us through that hard, cold winter. After my big brother left home and migrated to Iran, I became the oldest son, so I felt responsible for protecting our possessions and home. I should be brave, because of my family.

"Jamal!" What are you staring at? Come on, it's time to go. We are almost there," my older cousin Mohammad said as he was walking towards the village with his two other friends, Jawad and Juma Khan who were villagers and our neighbours. I could barely see what was in front of me because of the fog.

"Guys, walk faster! We should get to the village until there is fog or else we don't know what will happen to us," Mohammad said, checking his surroundings. The snow was falling gently, almost ghost-like, disappearing into the mist before it reached the earth, where a thick layer had already coated the ground. My heart was beating faster as we were getting closer to the village. We were halfway through the village, I could see the blue metal door of our house that was rusted over time.

"That's our house Mohammad! I can see it!" I pointed at its direction excitedly. He smiled and said nothing. Mohammad had the same reasons as me for going back home. The memory of that day is still very clear. It was a sunny but cold day. The valley seemed more crowded than ever. It was the only safe place where ¹Hazara

¹ Hazara People are an ethnolinguistic group in Afghanistan who have faced significant marginalization, persecution, and displacement, perhaps most zealously by the Taliban in the late 20th and early 21st centuries.

people escaped during conflicts between Hazara forces and the government of Taliban. It was protected by huge mountains and was hard to reach. We were staying in my sister's house who had got married recently. It was a very big, two-floor dirt house where my sister and her husband along with her husband's family lived. A lot of our relatives had come to stay there. I was overwhelmed by the crowd in the house. So I wore my coat and stepped outside. The valley was covered with snow. Giant mountains and hills, wide green fields of wheat and brown dirt houses painted unevenly with white color, made it look like a beautiful and magnificent painting. My sister's house was up on a hill and in front of the house, down the hill was their garden where they grew apples, apricots, vegetables and walnuts. I saw Muhammad standing on a flat rock down the hill, speaking with two other men. I walked towards them and overheard them talking about going secretly back to the village. When he saw me, he quickly said goodbye to those men and walked towards me with a nervous look.

"What are you doing here Jamal." he grabbed my shoulder, "let's go inside, the weather is cold."

I stopped and stared at him. "Are you planning to go home?" He awkwardly moved his hand away from my shoulder and placed it in his pocket, and quickly responded "No, who said that!" trying to look away.

"I heard you talking about it with those men." He did not say anything and just stared at a distance. "I want to go too. Take me with you." I said as I stood in front of him like a soldier going to war, trying to look serious.

He glanced at me, and raised his eyebrows with disbelief. "Jamal, you are just a kid. I can't just take you there." Laughing as he walked towards the house.

"If you don't take me with you, I will tell my uncle what you want to do."

He stopped and paused for a moment. Then turned back, "okay, okay! Don't go too far." said with a frustrated voice.

"You are my cousin Mohummad, although you are older than me, we are friends and we have always done everything together. I want to go too." I said, trying to convince him.

He stared at me blankly for a moment and then responded, "Okay then listen. We will go there tomorrow at 5 a.m Both of us should be beside the Mosques." he glanced at the door and continued, "we will split it up: one night in our place and one night in yours. That way we can take care of both houses and stay safe. Deal?"

I delightedly smiled with my teeth and responded, "Deal!"

Suddenly a strong wind surged through the arid plain, gradually chasing the fog away from the ground. The frigid strong wind brought me back to the present. Now we were standing in the middle of a snowy flat plain, looking like small black figures from afar. We all hold our breaths for a moment. I looked at my cousin. His face was pale and his eyes widened. "Let's go back, it was a bad idea from the very first," his friend Jawad said as he started running away from the village. Suddenly a loud noise echoed into my ears, and I quickly looked at Jawad. He was standing, holding his hands up staring at a distance. Gunshots were continuously fired around us. One

person shouted in ²Pashto: "Don't dare to run away or else we will shoot you in the head!" Another said: "if you love your life, continue your path!" His aggressive voice echoed in the empty plain. My throat was very dry and ached. I looked at my cousin, he looked back, held my hand and nodded his head. He looked terrified, his hands were trembling but his forced smile while looking at me made him seem calm at the same time. We continued our way to the village, as we were getting closer, I could see a bunch of men with long beards, wearing traditional clothes just like us but had black ³Afghan turban wrapped around their head. They held the "Ak-47" tightly in their hands. The curved magazine rested against their fingers and their trigger finger hovered just above the guard, ready to shoot us. They ran to us, their eyes were like hungry wolves hunting sheep who have lost their flock. I pressed my cousin's hand tightly as they were approaching us. One of them grabbed my wrists with a force that made my skin prickle. I could feel the burn of the string as he tied my hands tightly, I looked at the string that was wrapped around my tiny hands, the colour and material of it was familiar, it reminded me of that day: sun was shining and I was overwhelmed by the hot weather, but happy because my father gave me some cents to buy it for my sister after I begged for it for a long time.

"What colour do you like?" I asked her.

"Red," she answered, smiling.

"I will come back in a minute!" I could feel the heat targeting my head, as I was running to the only grocery store of our village, a tiny room with a blue metal door.

"Hi, uncle! Can you give me a string?" I said as I was breathing fast.

"Hi, Jamal! What colour do you want?" he asked.

"Red," I said while giving him the money.

"Which branch do you want me to hang it on?"

"That branch that's a little straight." she said with excitement. I climbed the tall pine tree and tightened the string there.

"Check, is it tight enough?" I asked her.

She put an old, thick, small, square mattress on it and sat. "Yes, it is tight." She swung a little bit, but stopped and turned her head up. "Don't you wanna come down and swing? We will take turns," she said and started swinging again.

"Sure! It isn't only for you," I said as I came down from the tree and we swung on that pine tree all afternoon until my mom called us for night prayer.

"Go ahead! Move!" One of them pushed me aggressively and I started walking towards somewhere following people I didn't know. The sky seemed darker now, after walking for a long time, they stopped in front of a house. It was Uncle Nasim's house, one of our neighbours. An old adobe house of a lovely family which was the military base of the Taliban now. Two men were walking back and forth on the rooftop with their fingers on the trigger. As we entered the yard, I noticed more soldiers inside. They were looking at us as if we were some dirty and stinky objects that they wanted to get rid of.

²One of the national languages of Afghanistan spoken by Pushtons.

³ Afghan Traditional Turban also known as Afghan Lungie is very common by the men of Afghanistan. It is a long scarf wrapped around their head.

“Get inside!” a man shouted, pushing me inside a dark room. My cousin and his friends were thrown like soccer balls inside there following me. As my eyes got used to the dark, I looked around. There were two cows, wearing handmade collars with heavy chains attached to them, standing in one corner of the room. I knew where we were as I could feel the numb soil under my feet and smell, the unmistakable odour of cow manure hung in the air.

“What would they do to us?” I asked Mohammad with a voice that was hardly coming from my dry throat.

“Only God knows. Don’t worry you, you are just a kid, they won’t hurt you...I hope,” he said hesitantly.

“I hope I will get to see my family again,” one of my cousin’s friends said with a shattered voice. “I have heard that they have killed some people from the neighbouring village because they were considered guilty of helping out the government and participating in the fight,” the other friend said.

No one spoke. I do not know how much time we spent in that dark room, when suddenly the door opened and a light targeted our faces.

“Get out,” the person said, holding the light toward us. I couldn’t walk properly. My feet hurt so bad because of sitting on the numb and muddy floor. As we got out three other shadowy figures joined, following us through somewhere. Everywhere was dark except the white colour of snow which was shining under moonlight. Clouds were gone and the full moon was clearly visible. After walking for a while, we entered a long thin corridor.

“Sit!” the same man said as he was putting his lamp in his pocket. Two other soldiers entered the room, one holding bread, the other a big teapot with glasses. They give each of us half a loaf of bread and a glass of boiled water with sugar in it. “Eat, if you don’t wanna die from hunger. This is the best thing you can get!” one of the soldiers said with a smirk on his face. The room was cold. I held the glass in my hand, the water’s steam was visible like fog or white smoke. I remember how my friends and I were breathing through our mouths while going to school on snowy days pretending that we were bad boys smoking secrets. I came back to reality as a soldier walked out of the room which was at the end of the corridor.

“Who is Mohammad?!” he shouted.

“Mm me,” my cousin answered hesitantly, still holding the bread in his hands.

“Come with me,” he said. I looked at Mohammed. He put his bread and glass on the ground. He smiled at me and pressed my shoulder, then started walking after the man. I was hungry and my throat was aching because of how dry it was. I grabbed the dry bread and started eating it with boiled water, desperate for something to fill me up and ease my hunger. I was getting my last bite of the bread when suddenly a loud sound came from that door.

“Oh no, please god... He isn’t killed, he isn’t, they didn’t shoot him!” I kept repeating to myself as I stared at the door. The door opened, and the same man came back, but Mohammad wasn’t with him. That was when I realised what the loud sound was for.

“Who is Jamal!” he said as he was analyzing us.

"Me," I said with a trembling voice.

"Come with me," he said. As I got close to the door my heart beat faster and faster, as if it wanted to get out of my mouth. I entered the room. It was very dark and only one small light was placed on the table in the middle of the room. I looked around but no one was there.

The man shoved me forward and said: "Sit on the chair!" I sat, glanced at the table, which had the words "1919 the independence of Afghanistan" written on it with a blue pen, conveying where the chair and table came from. My friends used to cheat during exams by writing them on their tables, hoping the teacher wouldn't notice it. We never had chairs or tables in our houses. We slept and sat on mattresses made by our mothers and did all of our homework while sitting cross legged on the floor. I quickly turned my head up as I heard the sound of footsteps echoing in the empty room. A door opened in front of me, I didn't notice it because of the darkness. I stared at the door and saw a man appearing in the doorway. He was short and his big belly made walking hard for him. As he came closer I noticed that he had one arm, and a big scar was on his cheek. He was wearing a white traditional cloth and a white Afghan Turban unlike others who were wearing black.

"What are you staring at, young man! Did my arm scare you?" he asked with eeriness. I quickly turned my head down and said nothing. He sat and said while staring into my soul. "Hahaha of course you should be scared! The weak should always be scared of the strong! But I can be your friend if you would be a good boy and answer my questions truthfully," he said with a creepy smile. I did not say a word. He was scary but instead of fear, his words and appearance created a sense of hatred in me rather than fear. "Ok Jamal! Tell me, who in this village was helping the Government? Hmm?" he said with a calm voice.

"I do not know. I came here with my cousin just to go home," I said, trying not to sound weak.

"You are obviously telling me you are from this village but you didn't notice anyone fighting against us or feeding our enemies?" said , staring into my soul with his sharp and cold eyes.

"Sir I told you the truth, I don't know anything." I said as my face muscles tensed. He suddenly threw his chair to the other side of the room and grabbed me by my collar and brought his face so close to me that I could feel his nasty breath on my face. His eyes were glaring, "Don't you dare to play with me, little boy! Do you want to die just like your cousin? Ha?" he said, clenching his teeth.

"I swear, I don't..." I hadn't finished my sentence. He released my collar. All of a sudden his big fist hit my mouth and threw me like a lightweight doll to the ground.

"Soldier!" he shouted, the same man who brought me into the room came. "Take this bastard child and make him spill the truth!" I could taste the salty flavour of blood in my mouth. I felt dizzy and couldn't stand on my feet. The man came up to me. He was very tall, I could barely reach his waist. He grabbed my arm and pulled me up. I felt like he was going to cut my arm by pressing it. "Get up!" He shouted. I could not see anywhere, my eyes were filled with tears but I was holding them. I did not want to look weak and cry like a kid to make these evils feel happy and think I gave up. He

held my arm and pulled me harshly through the doors until I could feel cold and fresh air blowing into my face. After a few steps he stopped and threw me to the ground. I could not feel any pain, I just wanted to sleep, to rest, I wanted to go home. "Get up! It isn't time for sleeping!" the man shouted, his voice echoing through the air. I looked around. I was in a field, it was the same field where we played football, right behind Uncle Nasim's house which was their military base now. "Look, this is your cousin and his friend!" the man said. I followed where he pointed the small light on and suddenly I started shivering, as if someone was giving me an electro-shock. Everything seemed unreal to me, I couldn't hear anything anymore. My eyes were wide open staring at two corpses covered with white clothes.

"No way! He is dead," I muttered to myself.

"Do you consider yourself so brave to not tell the truth to the general? Hah?! Tell me the truth: who was fighting against us from this village? Who fed our enemies?" He kept asking me those kinds of questions while I had no idea about them. I was a child, who just wanted to return home. How do they expect me to know about all this stuff?

"I do not know anything, I already told you sir," I said, trying to ignore the dead bodies rolled in white covers in front of me.

"It seems like you aren't going to talk. Now we will see how brave you are," he said with a smirk on his face. "Lay down between those two corpses, now!" He pushed me towards them and shouted "Go!" I was really terrified, that was the first time I experienced such a fear. I was so shocked that I could not even cry. I was just standing there like a statue in the field surrounded by three big men and soldiers on the rooftop of Uncle Nasim's house, not knowing what to do.

"Don't you hear me? Go!" the man shouted again.

I could hear my own heart beat, "dub, dub, dub," as if it wanted to get out of my body by bumping itself to the surface of my chest. I could hardly open my mouth, the only word that came out of my mouth was "No," with a shaking voice.

"No! Look guys, this little kid is playing with us! Can you believe it!" he said, facing his two other friends while his eyes were widened. I looked at three of them. They were laughing, their teeth were shining in the dark and their eyes were glaring. If evil was human, he would definitely look like them. I thought to myself, "Please God, take me home." I mourned to myself as the sound of their laughs filled the wide field.

Suddenly he struck me on the shoulder with the butt of the rifle and I fell to the ground, then all three of them began to hit me with their heavy feet. My body was curled up on the ground as I tried to cover my head and protect myself while the kicks kept coming. They were kicking me as if I was a ball in the middle of a soccer field rather than a human. I felt the pain deep in every cell of my body. Every kick was like an electroshot that made my body tremble. After a while those electroshot stopped. My body was in so much pain that even crying was not enough to heal it. Throughout the whole time I did not scream even once. I was tired, so tired that I couldn't even raise my voice. I heard one of them say: "Hey check! Is he alive?" The man who was apparently their captain, the one who kept me questioning, bent and held my chin upwards. "It is your last chance, tell me who helped our enemies from

this village. Otherwise I will kill you!" He stared into my eyes. He was young, maybe in his mid twenties. He had a beard just like other soldiers and a scar just above his eyebrow which made him even more scary. "I already told you I don't know anything, if you want to kill me then kill." I told him, staring into his eyes with a voice that was hardly heard due to the pain that I had on my chest and stomach. I knew they killed my cousin. I did not have any hope of survival. If they had the courage to hit a little child this hard and force him to lay down between dead bodies then they could do anything. They had no mercy. I would rather die than suffer anymore. My weak and thin body could not bear anymore pain.

He looked at me with disbelief and sarcasm. "So it seems like you have decided your faith." Then he turned back to one of the soldiers and said: "Take him there, it looks like a good place for shooting at your target!" The man grabbed my arm and pulled me along with him. He made me sit on a big flat rock. That was when my eyes started to water. I was filled with different emotions: fear, regret and abhorrence. I hugged my legs and placed my head on them facing downwards.

"Sorry mom! I am a bad kid. Sorry for leaving you and dad. Sorry for disappointing you. Sorry," I mumbled to myself, tears dropping from my eyes, unstoppable, as if they had not cried for a long time. As I heard the sound of the trigger being pulled, I hugged myself harder with my little hands, that I no longer could feel because of the cold.

I could also hear someone from a distance shouting at them: "Guys, he is a little kid, don't go too far. Do not kill that innocent child!" Probably a soldier from the rooftop. I pressed my eyes with stress and was ready to die. "Please god, let this one be without any pain, please," I said my last words. He pressed the trigger but no sound came out.

"What happened?" I thought to myself.

"You are lucky! My gun has run out of bullets, otherwise you would have gone to the other world," he said with disgust. "Bring him in!" He ordered one of his soldiers.

The soldier grabbed my arm and made me stand. I could barely walk, my legs were shaking from the blows they had taken. My back was aching as if I had carried a big rock on my back or slept on snow outside. He pushed me forward and said "Move!" I hobbled along and tried to walk faster so he wouldn't push me again. I had already suffered enough and was enduring a lot of pain. I did not want him to push me aggressively again with his heavy hands which made my back and shoulders hurt more. He opened the door of the yard; after passing the barn, we entered the house but this time he changed his way and stood in front of a door just beside the entrance door. He took a bunch of keys out of his pocket and after a while, he turned a key inside the lock of the old wooden door and it opened.

"Get inside," he said calmly. As I entered, I froze in my spot like a statue. I rubbed my eyes quickly to make sure I was not dreaming.

"Oh god, oh god! You are alive Jamal! Are you okay? Is your body aching? What have they done to you? Oh god! Why do they do this to a kid!" he kept questioning me while he rushed to me.

I could not hear anything and just stared blankly at him. "You are alive, Mohammad," I muttered.

He stared at me. His eyes were red and full of tears ready to fall. He hugged me.

"Yes, I am alive," he said with a shattered voice.

"Ugh! It hurts," I said.

"Oh sorry, sorry," he said softly as he got his hands off of my shoulders.

We had not finished our conversation yet, and that man came in again and pointed at us: "All of you! Follow me." My cousin took my arm and gently helped me to walk out of the house. The person changed his path to where the barn was. He stopped in front of the weathered wooden door of the barn and turned a key inside its lock. The door opened and we were pushed inside. I did not have energy for anything. Each heart beat was synced with waves of pain all over my body, as if bees were stinging me with every breath. I laid down on the moist, soil-covered ground beside my cousin and hugged my arms. My eyes slowly got heavy and they closed. I could hear birds happily singing, celebrating the arrival of the day. My eyes opened.

"Jamal, wake up, it is prayer time," my cousin told me as he sat in front of me on the ground. His appearance was not better than mine, his upper lip had a big scar and he could barely open his right eye. I tried to get up but my back hurt so badly it felt like it was about to break apart.

"I can't, I can't move my body," I said as I squeezed my eyes. Mohammad grabbed my shoulder and helped me to get up.

The door opened and a man came in. "Let's go, wash your face! It's time for prayer," he spoke aggressively. I looked around for the first time since last night and found out that the other two of us were also in the room with us which made me feel eased. We followed the man as we were surrounded by three other soldiers. "How do they expect us to pray with these dirty clothes when they kept us in the barn on dirt with cows?" I thought. They led us to a narrow water channel close to the house. The snow had covered everywhere, even the dead thin branches of the trees beside the water channel. I sat down and put my hands into the water. The water was flowing gently over the channel. "I wish I were water; no matter how much I was hit by rocks and valleys, still I would keep flowing, I thought to myself.

"Hey, don't play with water! You should pray before the sunrise!" one of them shouted. I got water in my hands and poured it on my face. The water was cold, very cold but clear like a mirror. I glanced at my reflection in the water, my face was unrecognizable, small and big scars all over my cheeks and neck made me look like I had been in a fight with someone. I wish I could fight back but I was just a kid against three grown men. Can a lamb defend itself against three massive wolves? We were taken to the same room that I saw my cousin last night, I stood and started praying, despite the pain in my legs, I kept bowing down in prayer. I learned praying at a young age and have loved it since then. It made me feel connected to God. It was a way to ask him for anything I wanted. Of course he did not fulfil all my wishes, but those prayers gave me hope of achieving them. Those prayers made me work harder and that was the most beautiful side of prayer. When I finished my prayer, I held my hands up and said: "Thanks for watching over me. Thanks for giving me the

strength to get through all this pain. Please relieve my pain, dear lord. I want to go home. Please help me get out of here. I promise I won't disobey my parents again. I promise I'll be a good kid, please!" I kept saying those words while tears fell down through my cheeks. After a while I stopped crying. The door opened and the two men came in.

"Resting is enough, you are not guests here! We have a lot of work to do. Hurry up!" My cousin stood up and glanced at me, I could see the worries in his eyes as he murmured: "Jamal, let's go." I stood up, but my leg muscles were not ready to move, with every step a wave of pain engulfed my entire body. As we stepped outside, the cold weather and thick layer of snow on the ground made it even harder to walk.

"Hey kid move faster!" one of them shouted. I huddled as fast as I could, so they would not hit me again. The sun was shining, but it seemed like it did not have any warmth. We kept following the eight armed men, who surrounded us. We passed by the ruins in the village, a bunch of mud houses, their walls riddled with bullet holes, informing us that we were heading to the frontline. After walking for a while, I noticed three other people who were also arrested from other areas. They seemed tired, their faces were pale and filled with bruises. The armed men stopped.

"Get these strings and tie it around your waist," one said as he threw the thick blue strings at us.

"Is it deep?" one soldier asked.

"Yeah, these three wells are deep and the General wants us to look for weapons inside them, but why should we take the risk when we already have these servants?" He glanced at us with a smirk. The other laughed. Mohammed and his friend were led to the first well between two bushes. The other three were led to the wider well in between by two soldiers. I and another friend of his were led through the other well beside a pine tree. As a kid I was afraid of wells. My mom always told us that a big monster was sleeping deep down in the well and would eat any child who bends their head down into it. As we got closer to the well, my heart beat faster and faster, but this time I did not say no, because I did not want to be beaten up again. I was like a cracked porcelain statue, ready to shatter with the slightest blow. They tightened the other end of our string to the tree and told us to go down. My legs were not hurting. I could not feel them anymore because of the cold. I pressed my eyes together and hung my legs into the well, still holding the ground tightly until I found an unevenness on the well's wall to put my foot on.

"Get this flashlight and search for weapons." One soldier said as his eyes glared at me. I turned the flashlight on and held it tightly in my left hand. I slowly descended into the dark well. As I neared to the bottom, my muscles tensed with fear and I clenched my teeth harder and harder, as if trying to hold back the panic rising inside me. The two soldiers held the string and helped us to go deep down one by one. The well was dark, but warm. I shone the flashlight down to see how much water it had, but I was completely dry, maybe it had been dry for years. I looked around. There was not a sleeping monster but a dead lizard in the corner and some spider webs on the earthen walls of the well.

After checking for a while the man who was with me in the well shouted: "There are no weapons!"

His voice echoed in the well. No one answered. I looked up and saw both soldiers speaking with each other in Pashto.

"What are they saying?" the man murmured with himself. I glanced at him and then tried to hear what they were talking about. As I heard each word coming out of their mouth, my eyes got wider and wider. Mom was right about monsters but she did not tell me that sometimes monsters can be in the shape of a human and outside of the well.

"Let's shoot them. If anyone asked, we would claim that they attacked us and tried to escape. What do you think, huh?"

I knew how to speak Pashto because I went to school with Pushtons for my first five years of school, therefore I could easily understand them.

"Why is your face so pale Jamal? What are they saying? Speak, why are you silent?"

The man, my cousin's friend, kept asking me while trying to be as quiet as possible.

"They want to kill us," I whispered effortlessly as I looked up. He stared for a moment and then sat on the ground holding his head between his hands. I could see the muzzles of their weapons being pointed down into the well. Their conversation stopped. I held my breath and squeezed my eyes shut, waiting for the rain of bullets to fall. Suddenly everything felt so quiet as if time had stopped.

"What are you guys doing?! Did they find any weapons?" Suddenly a voice came and the muzzles of their weapons went off of the well.

"Th-the they did not find anything sir." One soldier's voice came.

"Then why are you waiting? Get them out of the well! We don't have time!" their captain shouted.

"Yes sir!" The string dropped into the well and we got out of there. The two soldiers stared at us as if we had committed a very inhuman crime. Their eyes were glaring while they pushed us aggressively forward. We passed the damaged and empty houses as we arrived back to their military base. The soldiers took us to the same room we prayed in and locked the door. The room was pretty small. I looked at others, their clothes were cracked in mud, with patches of brown sludge staining the fabric especially around their knees and shoes. Their lips were dry, cracked and chapped with small flakes of skin peeling away. The dark circles around their eyes showed how tired they were. The growling of my stomach snapped me back to the present, and reminded me that it needs food. I had not eaten anything since last noon. They gave us just one meal per day, which was more than enough according to their thoughts. I sat down beside my cousin on the floor, and tried to ease a little bit of my leg pain by massaging them softly with my little hands. The key turned inside the door's lock and the door cracked open. Two soldiers came in. One of them was carrying a large, grey iron kettle, its surface darkened from being left too long over the fire, and the other held cups and dry pieces of bread in a big old bowl. They gave us each a small piece of bread and a cup of boiled water. I ate it with a lot of joy, thankful that I got something to feed myself with.

We spent the nights in the barn. The walls made of mud were rough and uneven and the air was thick with the pungent smell of cow's manure. The ground was damp and soft beneath our feet, which worsened my back and legs pain. Everyday that I woke up, new bruises appeared all over my body. Some were big, and some were small. Insects had a better feast than we did. Most nights I wondered if the night had turned to a nightmare, and I was the only one who had not woken up from it. A sudden relentless cough jolted me awake, reminding me it was not a nightmare but the reality. Each persistent cough rattled my chest and burned my throat. My head was aching as if it was inside boiling water. I opened my eyes and looked at the tiny window, the sky was dark blue and the birds singing came from a distance. I was lying on the damp soil of the barn, shaking from the cold. I remembered how my mom made a big thick blanket for me with the goat's wool. During the long cold winter nights lying under that heavy and thick blanket was as enjoyable as getting a box of candy for free. I remembered her smile and the sparkle in her eyes while she showed me the blanket.

Suddenly a drop of tear fell from the corner of my eyes. "What is she doing? Is she thinking about me? Is she mad?" I questioned myself silently. Since I was young, I was a rebellious person. I always wanted to go wherever I pleased. Despite my mother's objections, I would sneak out of the house and go to the neighbouring village to play with my friends and visit my aunty. At that time the world was colourful for me. I never knew the Taliban. I never knew they could beat a child to death because he just returned back home. I closed my eyes trying to go to sleep again. We spent three days in their base, when finally they decided to take us to the Bazaar where it was considered to be the main place of Taliban in all over the district. The snow was falling slowly, and the morning breeze gently caressed my bruised face, now tinted with shades of green and purple. My cousin and I, with the rest of the group, were standing at the side of the dirt road, waiting to be taken to the Bazaar. Bazaar was an old place where people bought their needs from. There was the hospital, shops and the main base for the military, which was now conquered by the Taliban.

"Hey kid! Come here," One of their soldiers that I had not seen before called me. My legs were still in pain but better than the first day. I hobbled and went to him. "Do you know how to cook?" He asked an unexpected question that made me pause for a second.

"No sir," I said while staring down at the snow beneath my feet.

"No matter, I will teach you. I was thinking of keeping you here with me and making you cook for us," he said as he was smiling. I was shocked and did not know how to respond. One of them beat me to the death and now this one wants to keep me here?

"I am sorry, sir, but I will go wherever my friends are going." I said with a stable voice. Prison was better than working for you, I thought.

"I swear you will go to the Kandahar prison soon! Get lost!" he said. I quickly turned and walked back to where my cousin was. My cousin looked at me and said nothing. The soldiers came and wrapped our hands with ropes. We started walking. The

weather was cold and the snow was falling steadily. My old coat and shoes offered little warmth. My teeth were chattering uncontrollably. We were surrounded by ten or fifteen soldiers. Whenever anyone slowed down, a soldier would prod them with the muzzle of his rifle. The distance from our village to Bazaar was very long; we had to walk through villages. We passed two or three other soulless villages scarred with bullet holes, before finally reaching the villages where life appeared again. People were shaking their heads and whispering to each other, while children were staring at us with confusion. I could smell the scent of bread from homes and hear the laughter of children while playing and running around. Apparently only the villages near the front line were cursed with desolation. My legs started to hurt telling me that they need rest, but I could not slow down even for a second. I never imagined Bazaar being this far. Suddenly I felt something hard on my back that made my body move two steps forward.

"Hey don't slow down, we don't have time!" said his voice breaking between deep and high tones. I turned and quickly looked back while I stumbled faster not wanting to be hit again. A boy, probably 15-16 years old, an inch taller than me had wrapped his face with a black scarf. His eyes glaring as he was shouting at me to move faster. We walked through the villages and dirt roads until I could finally see some small dirt buildings appearing one by one as we were getting closer.

The Bazaar was not the way I imagined it to be. It was not bustling with people, colourful toys and snacks. It felt abandoned. We walked through the dirt street that was lined with big and small shops on both sides. Most shops were locked and only a few were open. I stopped taking in my surroundings as the soldiers halted in front of a dirt building. I looked up. It was a two-storey mud building with a big wooden door. Several soldiers were keeping watch on the rooftop. One soldier went forward and knocked at the wooden door. The door creaked open and a middle aged man came out. He was wearing a green traditional cloth with black Afghan turban and had a long black beard that reached to his chest.

"We brought the prisoners we spoke of a week ago," one of the soldiers said.

The man studied each of us with sharp eyes before responding, "Come in."

We entered. The yard was filled with Taliban soldiers. all staring at us with a look of disgust and anger. We followed the man and went inside the building. We passed the dark narrow corridors until the man stopped in front of a cell, turned a key inside a rusty lock and opened it. The soldiers cut the rough, abrasive ropes binding our hands. The rope had left red, burn marks around my wrists, which ached as I rubbed them. They took us inside one by one and locked the cell. There were 15 more prisoners there. The cell was small and cramped. Nights were cold and uncomfortable. There was not enough space for everyone to lie down, so we had to sleep in shifts most nights. Most nights I could not sleep properly. My back and my neck ached from the hard floor. The birds singing came from a distance.

I was sleeping on the rough dirt floor of the cell, when suddenly the metallic rusty door of the cell creaked open with a loud noise that made me jerk awake and quickly open my eyes. The same man from yesterday appeared followed by two other soldiers.

He pointed out to a number of prisoners including me and ordered, "You, you, you and you, stand up and come with me."

I rubbed my eyes with my little hands that had been marked with deep, raw cuts from the cold. I looked at my cousin, his eyes were tired, filled with worry, as he sat beside me. He nodded and forced a weak smile. I stood up and joined others. We passed the dark corridors of the prison and stepped outside of the building. After days of being imprisoned, the fresh weather felt very pleasant. We passed the yard, and he opened another wooden door that led to a path leading to the fields at the back of the prison. A fresh layer of snow had covered the ground and the sun was shining so brightly on the snowy fields that made me squeeze my eyes in order to see through.

"Take off your shoes!" he said loudly.

I stared at him with confusion. Why should we take off our shoes? I thought. I was still in my own childlike world and did not have any idea about what they wanted to do to us.

"Can't you hear! Take Off Your Shoes!" he shouted with anger.

I quickly took off my shoes and put them aside.

"Take off your socks, too, little man," the man said with a smirk.

I took off my socks and put them in my shoes.

"Now all, stand in a straight line!"

I stood; the layer of snow was thick on the fields. My feet were now covered in snow. One soldier came with a plastic watering can and poured cold water on our feet. I slowly began to feel the pain. The pain was overwhelming, after a minute, my legs started to shake. I bent my body up and down; I clenched my teeth and pressed my eyes, but the pain did not seem to stop. It was the most painful thing I had ever experienced.

"If any of you get their feet out of the snow, I will make you stand here for the whole day! Crazy people, you should have thought of this when you were helping our enemies!" the man shouted at us while he was laughing. My feet were very cold. It felt like someone was stabbing them with needles. The sun was shining but its light did not have any warmth. After a while the pain disappeared as if I did not have feet.

"The water is ready sir!" a soldier shouted.

"Bring it here." the man said. A few minutes passed and a soldier came. He was wearing grey traditional clothes with a black Afghan Turban wrapped around his head. He was carrying a big metal water pot from which steam was rising. He poured hot water on everyone's feet in order. At first it was very calming but right after he stopped pouring water, my feet started hurting even worse. It felt like it suddenly woke a monster up who eventually started biting my feet again.

"Put on your shoes now. Quickly!" he said as he picked some snow from the ground and started rolling it. Everyone quickly got their feet out of the snow. I held my socks in my hands and wore my shoes. They sent us back to the cell. Then they took a number of other prisoners out. Everyone was groaning from pain. I sat and looked at my feet. They had turned dark purple. My toes were hurting. I put on my thin socks that had some small holes and started rubbing my feet with my hands to make them

a little bit warmer, but I could not feel them. My feet were hurting so much that I could not resist anymore.

A tear dropped down my cheek. I quickly wiped it. I did not want to seem weak in front of these monsters. I was a man and just like my father was always saying "Men don't cry." But still before being a man, I was a little child who could not tolerate that amount of pain. I could not control my tears. I constantly rubbed my eyes to stop my tears from falling down. "Why do they do this to me? Huh? What have I done wrong? Is it a crime to return to your home?" I kept repeating these questions in my head, but could not find any answer.

During the one month we were there, They made us suffer everyday, sufferings that would have a long term impact on my life. It was one month since we were taken to the Bazaar prison. I could see the sadness, hopelessness and frustration in the eyes of prisoners. Their eyes had lost their shine. Everyone was waiting to be taken to the main prison of Taliban "the Kandahar prison" which had no way back. Our life had turned into a nightmare that was not supposed to end. Since the day we were captured, neither of us were allowed to shower. I had the same clothes on me for more than a month. I could not sleep properly at night, because of the head and body lice feeding on my blood. My entire body and scalp were itching, and many areas of my body had turned red or developed wounds from constant scratching. I had come to despise myself and want to escape this pain and suffering. All I wanted was to close my eyes and like brown bears fall into a deep, peaceful sleep to survive that painful winter. A sleep that would last forever. I hated the sunrise, birds singing, people, and myself. But it seemed like I was not going to fall into a long pleasant sleep soon.

"Everyone! Get up. It's time for morning prayer. Quick! the sun would rise soon." The soldier kept repeating those words as he opened the lock of the cell.

I opened my eyes and sighed, trying to stand up. My feet were still hurting. We walked out of the dark corridors of the prison and headed to the yard, where a small washroom was sitting in the corner. Everyone had to stay in line to use it. And the line was long. I observed my surroundings as I waited to use the washroom. People were constantly scratching their hair and body; their clothes were dirty and it seemed as though they had not showered in months. How would God accept our prayers in this situation? Aren't we supposed to talk with God with a neat and clean appearance? It seems ridiculous. The Taliban insist on praying on time, yet they do not even know how to behave with other human beings, I thought to myself.

"Your turn!" the soldier said his face twisted with disgust. After completing the necessary steps of ablution, washing my hands, nose, face and wiping a part of my head with wet hands, I bent down to wipe my toes. I pulled my feet out of my shoes. As I touched them, I felt a sharp pain shot through me. My feet had returned to their normal color, but my toes were still dark purple.

"What are you doing Jamal?" Mohammad, my cousin asked, his hand resting on my shoulder. "Come on, the sun will rise soon. We do not want to be beaten again." I quickly put my shoes back on and we were all led back to the cell. The cell was very small. The reflection of sunlight from the small square window was the only reminder

of time passing. I sat down to pray, my legs folded underneath me and my hands resting on my lap. The cramped space made it impossible to stand up and bend, lower my gaze or place my head on the ground as usual because of the small space, so I prayed while sitting still, reciting the verses. It made me think of an old man I once saw in a Mosque. At the time it was very strange for me to see someone pray while just sitting. I looked at him with confusion and pointed him out to my father. "Dad, look how that man does the prayer." My father looked at me and explained while smiling: "His leg and back hurts and he can not stand or bend properly. That's why he prays while sitting." He stroked my hair and added: "Always remember God does not want you to suffer while worshiping and talking to him. He accepts you as long as you truly want to speak with him."

As I sat there, the memory made me feel warm inside. We all started praying. I could hear others whispering the verses as they were sitting, their hands resting on their laps. "Maybe it does not matter how messy you look, or how you pray," I thought. "As long as you do it from the heart, it will be accepted." No matter how hopeless I was, the prayer fired up a very tiny light in my heart called hope. The hope of going back home.

Days passed as we were waiting to face our end while trying to keep the tiny light in our hearts shining. It was almost noon and the sun was shining in an overwhelming way through the tiny window. I was tired because of the lack of sleep and could hardly move. I heard footsteps in the distance.

"Is it time for the noon prayer? Or they want to beat us again?" I thought to myself while sitting in a corner. A man came in. He was wearing black Afghan traditional clothes and had a long beard just like other Taliban members.

He opened the cell. "All of you are free, get out," he said while holding the door open and staring at us.

"What? Free? Am I really going home?" I murmured, "No, I must be dreaming," as I stared at his red sharp eyes with disbelief. Everyone looked at each other, their eyes wide and filled with hesitation.

"What are you waiting for?!" he screamed while observing everyone in the cell. "I've not gotten time for people like you!"

Everyone suddenly stood up. My cousin looked at me with a big smile. "Jamal, do you hear?" he shouted, his eyes shining again, "we are free! Free! I can finally see my kids again!" He kept screaming with excitement while resting his hands on my shoulders. We got out of the cell, passed the dark, numb corridors of the prison and stepped out of the wooden door of the two-storey building.

The man we met on our first day appeared across from the wooden door with a long black coat. He looked at us and said: "You have to stay around the Bazaar for a few days until each of you gets a confirmation letter from us which would let you pass our check points." He fixed his long turban, turned around and continued while walking back inside through the wooden doors: "you are lucky to get out of here!" The door closed following his sarcastic remark. I looked at people who I had spent a month with in that two-storey building. They all squeezed one another in a warm, tight embrace, their eyes glittering with joy and their lips curving into wide smiles as they

said goodbye to one another, before going on their way. One was excited to see his parents, one was excited to see his wife and children while another was excited to eat a real meal other than dry bread, their eyes filled with life and hope.

"What will we do now?" Mohammad asked, turning his head towards Jawad; a man with a small build who was in his mid 30s and much older than us. I put my hands in the pockets of my short black coat and waited for the answer. "There is a mosque nearby," he said as his eyes followed the movement of a white pigeon which was jumping like a tiny rabbit and eating the nuts that had fallen on the dirt ground of a small grocery shop across from the prison. He continued, "It is located where our own people are living, therefore we will be safe." Juma Khan nodded; a tall skinny man. He did not talk much and was very quiet, but I knew he had the same reason for leaving the valley. We all started walking on the dirt road that had been covered with snow. The Bazaar was still quiet, only some shops were open. As we passed by the row of shops my eyes fell on a sack of sugar placed in front of a shop. Everything started from a sack of sugar. Hazarah people could not even buy a sack of sugar without the permission of the Taliban because of some Hazarah rebellions that were against their government. One day a van filled with groceries was going to pass a few villages of Pashtoons and secretly be transported to where Hazarah people were living but it got caught. That was when the war openly started. "Here we are!"

Jawad, I looked at the holy place. Its walls were painted green, the windows and the wooden door were bright blue. A few green plants and flower pots were visible from behind the window. "Let's go inside." Mohammad said as he climbed the three little stairs. I took off my shoes and entered the mosque. The interior walls were painted white and the floor was covered with red carpet. A few mattresses and pillows were neatly folded in one corner, while a small white wooden cupboard stood in the opposite corner, neatly holding the holy Quran and prayer mats. The mosque was very quiet and peaceful. The rhythmic ticking of the wall clock was the only destructor, its steady *tick-tick-tick* echoing softly through the room. I glanced at the square wooden clock; its pendulum was at 12. "It is going to be prayer time soon—" I thought. The blue wooden door swung open with a soft squeak and an old man appeared. He was wearing white Afghan traditional clothes that perfectly matched his white beard, making him look almost angelic. He froze for a moment, then slowly started walking toward us. As if he realized that he had been staring awkwardly. His expression was kind. He did not ask why we were there or why we looked the way we did. His first question after greeting was, "have you guys eaten anything?"

Looking at me with his glittering smile. And that was how we survived.

"*What happened afterwards?*" I asked, taking notes on my laptop.

"We got the confirmation letter the day after and headed back home," he said, his hands resting on his lap.

"Did you go by car or walk all the way through?"

"There weren't a lot of cars around at the time, especially in villages." He paused, his eyes fixed on the distance. "I remember my feet were frozen as I walked through the snow, barely an inch tall, over the hills toward the valley."

"Was Mohammad with you?"

"No, he stayed in his father-in-law's house. I and Jawad decided to go back to the valley." He continued, his voice softening. "If I hadn't arrived one minute earlier, I would have died from the cold."

"What was your parents' reaction? Did they know you were alive?"

He paused for a moment, as if the video of that day was playing in front of him. Then he spoke again: "I walked into my sister's house and fell down beside the heater. My legs were no longer mine. I couldn't control them anymore. No one was in the house. It seemed like all the people in that crowded house had disappeared. My eyes slowly began to close, but a sudden scream broke the peaceful silence. It was my sister. 'Oh God! Oh my God! He is alive!' Then she continued, 'Mom! Mom! Come here! Jamal is back!' I could hear her saying, 'He's alive. He doesn't need a funeral. He is alive.' My mom came in and hugged me. It was the first time in a while that I felt safe and comfortable. Her tight embrace and warm kisses washed away all my pain."

"Did you ever go back home?"

"Yes, but we weren't in a good financial state. My dad wanted to go to Iran for work. He wasn't in good physical shape, so I went instead of him when I was in grade nine."

"Was it hard?"

"Of course, it was hard, but my older brother was there, so I went straight to his place. I remember I spent days working and nights crying for my mom in the first few weeks." He smiled softly.

"When did you come back?"

"When the Taliban was taken down, my parents sent me letter after letter to return and continue my education. I went back four years later when I was 18."

"What did you do after you graduated?"

"I studied in a military academy and became an army officer. I fought against the Taliban for 20 years..." He paused for a moment, then added, "which was all gone, like a powerful flood that washes away all your possessions, after the Taliban took control."

"Didn't they try to harm you?"

"There was a very severe fight in Helmand province where I was stationed. I couldn't go back to my home in Kabul for several months. So after the fight was over, I went to Kabul for a two-month vacation. A month later the Taliban took over Kabul. They couldn't find me there." He tilted his head to the side, then continued, "They even found my home in Kabul, but I had moved out at the time."

"How are you feeling about life now? Are you sad?"

He thought for a moment and said, "It was very painful for me to lose 20 years of my life for nothing, but I am happy here, in Canada. I am happy for my kids, who don't have to go through what I went through and are able to study and become good humans. I have always worked for my children, not for myself. Even in Afghanistan, I did everything for them so that they would be able to receive a good education and become wise individuals *who do not carry a gun, but a pen*." He smiled as he looked at his daughter sitting beside him.

A Butterfly with a Dream

I could hear the singing of birds and the morning breeze that playfully flew through the windows to declare the arrival of the day. Somewhere in the yard, my mother's voice called, "Fawzia! Wake up. It is time for morning prayer." I sat on my mattress, still half sleeping. "Why is it morning so soon?" I muttered with a groan. "Oh wait! Today is the day!" The thought struck me, and suddenly a surge of energy rushed through my body like a bolt of thunder crashing down. I jumped off of my mattress, hopping towards the door. Our house was a big, one-story dirt building with lots of rooms that surrounded the yard. I grew up with my cousins. My family along with the family of my two uncles were living in the same house. That was the tradition at the time, "Brothers should always be together and support each other." After going to the bathroom across the yard. I went to wash my face, the morning breeze was cold and refreshing just like the water that came from the well in our yard.

"Good morning;" a sleepy voice came from behind.

I turned around and saw her, "Why did you wake up so late?" I said with a smirk.

"Just as always I woke up earlier than you!" I continued. She huffed in annoyance.

"Are you done?" After a pause, she added "I need water."

"Yeah, I am!" I washed my hands and handed her the well's black rubbery bucket.

"oh, don't forget about where we are going today." I whispered. She frowned and tilted her head for a moment as if she wanted to transport some forgotten memory back to the top of her brain. Suddenly her face brightened and her sleepy eyes snapped awake. She nodded quickly and began to pull water out of the well with the bucket. I quickly went inside. Wore my little floral scarf and started praying. I was always excited for the prayer time. When I turned nine, my father bought me a beautiful little floral scarf. I wore that scarf during prayer times and stood behind my mother, repeating every word she recited. My mom always said that I was quick at learning and that I learned the prayer very quickly. After prayer, I folded my mattress and put it on the top of other sleeping mattresses in the corner of the room. Then I covered the pile of mattresses with a white cotton cloth that had blue daisies sewed on it. The room was painted white and the ceiling rested on thick wooden beams, rough and cylindrical like giant straws. Along on one wall hung a handmade white curtain, its edges embroidered with tiny blue flowers that mother had sewn with a fine thread.

The yellow wooden door of the room cracked open. She appeared wearing a black dress that had patterns of pink roses on it. A pink little scarf was covering her shiny black hair that matched the roses. "What do you think about my dress?" she said as she smiled.

"Wow!" I grinned, "Is that the dress uncle brought from the town?"

"Mm-hmm, He just picked it up from the tailor yesterday, but mom forgot to tell me." she spun, the pink roses on her skirt swirling like petals in the wind.

"It is beautiful"

she stopped mid-spin, "Should I wear it today?"

“ definitely!”, then I lowered my voice,” Today is a special day for both of us.” She giggled “ Then get ready and come to the living room.” She continued as she stepped out of the room.” Breakfast is waiting! “

I quickly nodded, rushing to the old wooden closet where my mom kept our clothes. *What should I wear?* I wondered as I touched my chain. After searching through my clothes, I found it. A green dress with yellow daisies on it. “ Well, I guess I can beg mom to let me wear it for just one day,” I murmured.

“ What exactly are you doing, Fawzia?” My mom said standing at the door with her hands on her waist.

“ Na,Nothing.” I said as I quickly closed the closet.

“ Wear it.” She said, “ But just for today. It is your new dress, therefore save it for Eid.”

I began jumping up and down with joy. “ Thank you mom! You are the most beautiful mom in the whole world!”

“ Enough with the flattery, get ready and go to the mosque.” She said as she smiled warmly.

I wore my floral dress, combed my hair and tightened the little scarf under my chain.”Oh, I should not forget.” I mumbled, rushing to the wall niche to take my Holy Quran. That day I put something extra in my bag. A new notebook that my brother gave me and a new pen I took from my dad. After drinking a fresh glass of cow’s milk, we went to the mosque just as we usually did. But today was going to be different for me and for my cousin. We both will go to school for the first time. We will study all kinds of things. The girls from the village always speak of their school. They say that they read stories, poems and they study math! That must be fun! “ Are you zoning out again?” my cousin, Nora said as she waved her hand in front of my eyes. “ Did you even hear what I was saying?” She said tilting her head towards me. “ ah, what were you saying?” I said as I collected my thoughts.

“ Here we go again!” she said with an overwhelmed voice.I said,” Just like the girls, today we will go to school. ‘ she added, raising her eyebrows,” Then they would not show off talking all day about how wonderful the school is, right?”

“ Yeah! You are right.” I said tapping her shoulder.” Let’s hurry, you know the teachers are coming to the mosque today.” I said as I started running.

“ Hay! wait for me! “ Nora shouted.

“ Come! Let’s see who gets to the mosque first!” I said as I was breathing heavily.

“ That’s not fair! You have already started.” She said as she was running towards me, holding her shoulder bag tightly.

The mosque was a one story dirt building. The wooden frame of the windows were painted bright blue, the interior walls were cream. You could spot a lot of flower pots through the wide windows. Who were sunbathing on the wall niches everyday.

“ Here we are.” I said as I was holding my waist, trying to breathe.

“ You know we did not have to run Fawzia!” Nora said as she was breathing heavily.

“ Let’s go inside!” I said running through the door.

“ You don’t change, do you?” she murmured as she followed me.

We went inside the Mosques. The scent of dust-covered prayer stones mixed with the scents of flowers on the wall niche filled the mosque with a pleasant aura. The sun was generously shining on the old red carpets that covered the floor. The teacher who taught us how to read the Quran, was sitting in his place as usual, turning one prayer bead as he whispered each word. We greeted him and sat on our spots. The Quran class started at eight in the morning and continued till twelve at noon. The younger children would study how to read the Quran, and the older ones who already knew how to recite the holy Quran would study poems of Hafiz. Me and Nora knew the Alphabet, so we were learning how to recite the words and sentences written in the holy Quran. As time passed, slowly but surely the mosque filled with students, one by one. The older students who were learning poems sat near the wall, their back resting against it. We, who learned how to recite the holy Quran, sat in rows in front of them. The younger children who learned the Arabic Alphabet sat in rows in front of us, near the Quran teacher. The teacher began asking students for their homework, as he always did. We started reviewing the pages he had assigned so we could pronounce the words correctly and avoid being punished. The mosque was quiet. The only sounds that distracted the silence was the chanting of words and the rustling of turning pages. My eyes were following the second hand of the round wall clock that was hanging above the entrance door. I was waiting for them. Like a baby bird who waits for its mom to teach it how to flutter its wings against the wild wind that flowed smoothly but fiercely.

"Hey," said Nora tapping on my shoulder, "Why aren't you reading?" she glanced at the teacher who was listening to the recitation of a student. I took my eyes away from the clock and began reviewing my homework. The wooden door of the mosque creaked, and slowly opened. I looked up quickly, "they are finally here," I thought to myself. Two men stepped in, they were wearing white Afghan traditional dresses and black blazers. "Hello Shiekh," one of the men said as he walked towards the Quran teacher who people called Sheikh. They both greeted the Sheikh and sat beside him on the gray mattress. The students were whispering as they analyzed the men. "Who are they?" one girl asked.

"You really don't know?" her friend said as she glanced at them. "They are the teachers from the school," she added.

"Hello everyone!" one of the men said with a big smile on his face.

"We are the teachers from the school in your village," the other man added as he observed the faces. "Do any of the girls want to get enrolled in the school?"

The room got filled with murmurs as the students looked at each other.

"Whoever wants to attend school please raise your hands," the man continued.

"Why only girls?" a little child asked.

"Well, because boys are already enrolled and their school begins in the afternoon." The other man said, smiling at the boy.

"Okay, does anyone want to come?" he asked, reminding everyone why they were there.

I raised my hand as high as I could. A few other girls, including Nora, did the same.

“ Well! Lets go to school now,” One of the men said enthusiastically. “ We need to test your knowledge.”

“ Is that okay with you Shiekh?” the other man asked, looking at our Ouran teacher.

“ Yes of course!” he said, smiling at him.

We packed our bags, put on our shoes and started following them. As we got closer to the school, I felt strangely impatient. As if I wanted to learn flying right away and quickly get to school. My hands were freezing cold even in the burning summer sun. I felt the butterflies in my stomach, finally being awakened, flapping their wings with all their might to escape the place they had stayed for years. I looked at Nora. She was clutching her dress tightly in her little fists as she walked behind the teachers. A wide one-story dirt building appeared in the distance. As we got closer it became more visible. *So this is the school.* I thought. It was far away from other houses, and located near the dirt road and agricultural fields. It had many windows and doors that were painted yellow. The teachers stopped in front of the wider door. One of them turned around and started talking.

“ This is where you will learn how to read and write,” he paused for a moment and continued,” but before that we should test how much you know,” A little cynic murmuring was coming from some of the rooms. I could hear the voice of children as they repeated the Persian Alphabet after their teacher. *From today on I will also be one of them. I will also learn how to read and write stories, how to play with numbers and learn the things that are unknown to me. From now on I will be holding a pen. From now on I will go to school.* “ Hey! you zoned out again?” Nora tapped my shoulder. “ Let's go inside.”

We passed a narrow hall and stepped into a room. The floor was covered with a blue carpet and the air was filled with the smell of chalk. An old blackboard stood on the one side of the room, its back resting on the wall. A couple of books were on a wall niche close to the blackboard. The two teachers sat on each side of the blackboard, each holding a book. “ Please sit in rows, now we will start,” one of the teachers said, opening the book. They both started asking the girls one by one.

Nora leaned in, her breath warm against my ear. “ Hey — what are they asking?”

“ I don't know,” I whispered, glancing at the teachers as they asked the two girls in front of them to read something from the book.

One of the teachers called: “ What is your name?”

“ Me?” I pointed at myself. He nodded. “ Fuzia, my name is Fuzia.”

“ Okay Fuzia, come here.” He started turning the pages of the book as if he was looking for something. Nora pressed my hand,” it is your turn!”

I felt the butterflies flapping their wings even with greater force. The teacher put the book in front of me. “ Can you read what is written on this page?”

I nodded and looked at it. The words were written in a different way. Unlike Quran lessons. They were bare, without the marks that guide you in reading them. But they were familiar. The title was the first word of the Alphabet,(Alef). “ Anar dana darad “ I said with an uncertain voice which translates to "pomegranate has seeds." He nodded his head and turned the page, “ read this part.” I analyzed the text. The title was “ Dal” , another letter of the Alphabet. “ Dal, Dawwood dastkash darad.” I read in

fits and starts— Dawwood has gloves. He nodded again, closed the book and pulled another book from the wall niche. Flipping through its pages, he looked at me.

“ What is 5+5?” *Five plus five?* I started counting with my fingers. “ Ten.” After asking a few other questions he closed the book and put it aside.

“ You are very smart!” he said with a big smile.” From tomorrow, you will start studying in second grade.”He continued, “ the classes start at nine in the morning and end at twelve at noon. “ I nodded and returned to my spot, scanning the room for Nora. She was at the other side of the blackboard being tested by the second teacher. After a while he closed the book and started talking to her. She nodded and stood up. As she was returning to her spot, she gave a big smile. A kind of smile that spilled all the light and vigor of her soul into the room.

“ How was it? ” I asked inquisitively.

“ He said I can come to school from tomorrow on!” She squeezed my hand, “ Can you believe it!” I smiled at her and nodded.

The sun was shining straight above us as we walked back home. We walked in silence, listening to the singing of birds, the wind playfully dancing through the branches of apricot trees, and the sound of water flowing through the channels. One thought pressed against my mind: *Would they allow us to attend school?*

“ Did you notice it too?” Nora looked at me.

“ The military base beside school?” I said, eyes on the ground. “ Yeah I did. Do you think it will be a problem?”

“ I don’t know, but I am sure our fathers don’t like it.” She twisted the corner of her scarf between her fingers.

I stopped and looked at her, “ Lets not tell them.” I said starting forward again, “ Our school hours match the mosque’s.”

Her eyes lit up, “ Yes! We can come here and they’ll think we are in the mosque. We have already learned the Quran anyway. ”

I nodded. Suddenly she bolted forward, “ let’s see who gets home first! Whoever loses, washes the dishes after lunch!”

“ Wait!” I called, chasing after her. We opened the old wooden door of the yard and stepped inside. I could almost hear the creak as it gently opened. The yard was quiet

“ it seems like our brothers have already left for school.” I murmured. I could smell the scent of rice and the warm potato soap drifting through the air. Nora’s mother appeared on the doorway of the kitchen, which was in the corner of the yard. “ Oh you guys are back from the mosque. Wash your hands and come inside.” she said heading toward the living room,” Everyone is eating lunch!”

The fragrance of pink and white rose lingered everywhere on the way, making the day even more pleasant. The loud laughing and talking of children was coming. “ Thankfully we are not late for the first day of classes.” I murmured. Everything was

unknown to me. The long paragraphs with bare words, the complicated numbers and the feeling of moving the pen on the white paper. In Quran classes, the only thing we did was reading the sentences following the marks and signs that were surrounding each word. The first day was much like an introduction. As we stepped outside of the class, I saw the military base again. The base was a small square, shielded by massive yellowish blocks, whether bricks or sacks of soil, I couldn't tell. Inside, soldiers waited, their guns aimed toward the school and the dusty road. "The teacher said he would give us our books tomorrow," Nora clapped enthusiastically, "oh I can't wait to see what is written inside those books."

"Me too!" I smiled at her bright eyes. I was happy, but unease tugged at me. My mom always said that "the sun can not be hidden with two fingers." I wondered how long we could hide it with our little fingers. The wooden door of the house stood wide open. As we approached, we saw my mom and Nora's mom waiting beside the well. Their faces were not as bright as yesterday. My mom approached us with tense, weary eyes. "You weren't in the mosque, were you?" My heart started beating wildly as if some thunder struck me inside. My throat felt dry and it was unable to transit words from my vocal cords. She held my arms and bent towards me, "Don't you know how dangerous it is to go to that school?" Her eyes were now filled with a strange kind of dull light, that screamed sorrow and worry, "Your father went to visit Sheikh in the mosque today but you guys were not there." Nora's mom, who had not said a word till now said, "Your fathers are inside waiting for you." Nora's face turned pale and her eyes were filled with tears. We opened the door of the living room. Father and uncle were sitting on the red mattresses, their backs resting against the white painted walls. We sat in front of them like criminals waiting for their trial. This time the silence was loud. They did not say a word for a while. The room was covered with red handmade carpets and a few plants were on the wall niches. My mom believed that the bright colors make the room brighter and cozy. But today even the sun was not able to send her warmth through the heavy air that surrounded us nor the wind could playfully blow inside. Suddenly my father started talking, "That school is protected by people we don't trust. It is dangerous. You are not going back." He paused for a moment, "You are our daughters and they might use this against us. Therefore you two are not allowed to attend school anymore." My brain could not handle the reasoning behind his decision. Who is the group? Why might they label children as enemies? Why are my brothers not targeted by this rule? Why just me? All these questions were rambling inside my head like a bunch of butterflies who have lost their way and are desperately trying to escape by smashing themselves violently to the walls. All I could think about was—nothing but emptiness. I tried to hold back my tears by pressing my lips together. I wanted to talk, I wanted to protest but I couldn't. As if some big heavy stone was stuck in my throat. They both left the room. I looked at Nora when I heard the door close. She was holding her dress with her fists tightly. Suddenly small drops of tear started to fall down her cheeks like pearls. That day was the last day we thought of going to school. The dream stayed as a dream for both of us. We grew up, finished Quran classes and were now young women. We took care of our younger siblings, learned cooking

food, baking bread and did embroideries in our free time to save up for our trousseau just like other girls in the village. I never talked back to my father that day, but getting an education would always be a dream for me. It is like a little twinkling star that little Fuzia could not reach even if she climbed the highest mountain in the world. The only way to reach the star was to fly, but her wings were taken away from her as they had just begun to grow. I still have the dream of that nine year old girl inside me. My wings were taken away, but I will make sure no one takes away my daughters wings when I become a mother. That is what I promised myself when I said yes to a marriage proposal. My firstborn was a girl. She had brown eyes that turned the color of honey in the sunlight, and hair that gleamed like gold under its rays. My husband was training in the capital to join the military, while I stayed in the village with my two children and my mother-in-law. Because the Taliban controlled the area, it was too dangerous for him to visit us. When my daughter turned four, we finally moved to Kabul, where my parents and siblings had settled years before. Unlike me, my sisters had been able to attend school, first in the village and later in the city. Years passed, and I was satisfied with my life. I became the mother of three other pretty girls and my first born was now fourteen. She and her brother were very good students. They had high grades and my daughter attended an English course after her school hours. My husband worked as a military officer in another province. We both promised to do whatever it takes to give our children the ability to grow their wings and fly as high as they want to reach their little stars. But it seems like good things do not last forever.

There was news everywhere about the domestic fights becoming more severe and how the Taliban has been taking over one province after another. I consistently called my husband but he was not picking up his phone. I still remember the day he left Kabul for that position. I protested to stop him from going somewhere that far and unstable but he said, "If I don't go, our children will not reach their twinkling stars." He packed his bag, wore his uniform and kissed our daughters and son one by one while they slept peacefully on their mattresses. *What if something has happened to him? Why is he not picking up the phone? It has been four days since we last spoke, where is he?* Those thoughts kept eating my brain and stole sleep from my eyes. My children were in their own world. Their med-term exams kept their minds busy. Finally on the fifth day, I heard his voice. "Hello, how are you?" He seemed to struggle speaking.

"Hi, I am good." I paused for a moment, "Are you okay? Why weren't you picking up the phone?" "I was worried rather than angry. I knew he would not spend a day without calling us. "Sorry, the phones were not working for the past week." he paused, I waited for him to continue speaking but he didn't seem to be on the other side of the phone.

"Hello?" Nothing could be heard except a heavy breathing. "Do you hear me?" I asked again.

"I am a little tired." He let out a big sigh, "Are the kids doing well?"

"Yes, they are all fine. By the way how is everything going over there?"

“ Everything is fine. As I told you, I am not going outside of the base.” His voice seemed cracked.” Were you asleep?” I asked.

“ Yeah, yes I was sleeping.” He paused for a moment, “ I had not slept last night—,” He stopped talking and only a cyclic breathing could be heard from the other side of the phone. “ Are you there? Hello?” No response. I looked at the screen, but the connection was not lost. He was still there ” why isn't he responding? “ I murmured. The connection was lost following a beep.

“ He said he is tired, maybe he wants to sleep.” My daughter said, writing something in her notebook.

“ But still he shouldn't have hung up like that.” I had a bad feeling about it. It was as if something was burning in my stomach. No matter how much water I drank, the flames did not snuff out. Those disturbing flames continued burning till the other day that I talked with him. His voice seemed fresher and lively.

“ Why did you stop talking and hang up like that yesterday?”

“ oh, about that? I just fell asleep during the call.” He continued with a sigh, “ I told you I was tired right?”

“ It has been five months, when are you going to come home?” I looked out the window, watching the bird drinking water from the muddy street, “ You know kids are asking about you everyday. “

He took a breath, the sound coming clearly through the receiver, “ I know, but no plane is available now for the Kabul flight.” He paused, “ You know I can't come by car either.”

“ I see,”

The kids talked a bit with him and then he hung up. When he first decided to go there, everyone objected, both my family and his. Probably because everyone knew what could likely happen to an army officer in a country where no one was safe, neither the sky birds nor the sea fish. Yet the birds still flew, drawn to the golden rays of sunlight above the clouds. And the fish still dived, following the god rays that touched the water. They did this, no matter how harsh the wind or water flow was. We, the inhabitants of the land, did the same. No matter how hard everything got, we lived. Seeing the god rays in the eyes of our children and the warm golden color of sunlight in their joyful smiles made us keep living. I would always remember those golden rays when their father came home without telling us any words before. The domestic war was always present in Afghanistan since I was a little girl, but now it seemed to be getting worse. The dark shadow of the Taliban seemed to take over the sky of one province after the other. Rumors were spreading everywhere like an unknown disease. Everyone stared at the TV, desperately looking for good news, but there was nothing. We clung to the news platforms, just like people cling to food.

I could hear the news from the kitchen, where I was preparing lunch. “ So it is already 12.” I thought to myself. We started consuming lunch in silence. Rice flavored with boiled raisins and fried carrots sliced like long noodles, a traditional dish called *Kabuli palov*.

“ These days a lot of girls in the school are talking about leaving Afghanistan.” My elder daughter swallowed the meal.” They say that Kabul is also going to be taken over by the Taliban.” Suddenly her dad glared at her, “ Don’t believe in everything you hear! I did not raise you like that.” He started playing with his food like a picky child, “ There is no way they can take over the capital.”

It seemed like there was a way. Rumours tend to become the reality very quickly, especially bad rumors. The military was giving up without fighting and there were videos on facebook where soldiers were crying saying they do not want to hand over their guns to those terrorists. It was clear like a day that the higher ups were selling off the military bases, at least that's what everyone said. When the Taliban entered Kabul, I along with my husband and our younger daughters were in the mall. People were running everywhere, their eyes filled with disbelief. It was like an apocalypse was happening, everyone looking for taxis and buses, just to get to their homes. The shops closed and crazy traffic covered the streets of the capital. I looked at my husband, he held the steering wheel tightly, his fingers turning white. His expression was calm but it seemed like a dark shadow had covered his face. “ No, it can't be true. No,” He muttered, staring at a distance. I looked at my younger daughters, Bitu seemed to be confused, she was staring on the crowded street. Yosra and Laalah were in their own worlds. Yosra was blowing air inside the empty juice box with its straw and Laalah’s playful eyes were watching the juice box with wonder as it was getting bigger and bigger with every blow of air. The apartment guard opened the big metal door of the garage and we entered inside the cool parking lot, where cars as well as the storage rooms of residence were located. We stepped out of the car, a white Toyota Corolla 2016 my husband had bought only months ago, just before he went back to work. I had objected, telling him not to spend nine thousand dollars on a car that would mostly sit in the garage. He only smiled, saying it was fresh from Canada and would sell for an even higher price later. He never did sell it at a higher price. Two months after the Taliban takeover, it was gone for six thousand. The garage itself was dusty and dark. We climbed the stairs and entered the apartment. A four story concrete building and our first modern home. We lived on the second floor. A suite that had three rooms. The walls were painted white and the ceilings were decorated with flowershaped ceiling moldings. It had two bathrooms covered with white glazed tiles which had blue patterns on them and a kitchen with eye-catching ceiling molding that had colorful lights on it. The entrance was opening to a narrow hall that led to the living room. We moved there when my husband got a job in a ministry in Kabul. We enrolled our daughters and son into a private school and sent them to English courses. Life was not peaceful at the capital but it was good, so good that no one could believe what had just happened. I knocked on the door and my sister-in-law opened it. Her face was pale and she began talking with a

trembling voice: “ I received a call from the person who is responsible to send us into Bangladesh for university,” She paused waiting for us to take off our shoes, “ So? “, my husband said standing in the narrow hall, “ she said get whatever you need and be prepared to leave.”

“ Oh, I see,” He said as he walked down the dark narrow hall into the living room.

“ It seems like they really took over.” she mumbled. Her eyes were glittering, the kind that you see on the water on a full moon night.

I looked at her, she was in grade eight when she came to Kabul to stay with us. Her brothers wanted her to attend a good university and the key to it was Kabul. She had recently got a scholarship in Bangladesh and was preparing to leave next month. “

Do not stand here, “ I said, staring at her,” Go get ready, who knows what will happen in this corrupted country a few seconds later.”

I went to the living room. The sun was shining dimly on the red Afghan carpet, revealing its yellow flower patterns brighter than ever. My husband sat on the mattress, staring at the tv as he switched channels waiting for the news. Wrinkles oppressed his forehead and his eyes desperately observed the tv, looking for a headline that said everything was a fake news, a rumor that had spread among people, but nothing popped up. As if the earth had opened its mouth and devoured all of the journalists inside. I observed the room for my eldest daughter who had just finished her midterm exams. She sat in the corner of the room staring at the TV, biting her nails. No one ate lunch properly that day as if our stomachs were full. In fact it was full, full of fear, uncertainty, anger and disappointment. Around 4:00 pm, finally the news appeared on the TV, with a big headline. I carefully analyzed the bare letters and finally read it,” The President Ashraf Ghani Has Fled the Country.” A moment later, bearded men with the white traditional clothes and black Afghan turban were sitting on the higher up’s chair declaring themselves as the new ruler and answering the Questions of journalists in the live broadcast. That was the only time I saw my husband’s disparate eyes stop rolling here and there. He looked like a defeated helmsman standing on his drowning ship. The sky was dark blue, as if the day had surrendered and draped it in a coat of grief. Grief for us and for our fate. I stepped into the narrow hall which seemed dimmer than before. A soft gentle voice was coming from the dark room beside the kitchen. Her voice was cracking mid-song, but she kept going. I looked inside, my eldest daughter was holding my youngest child, Laalah. Singing her lullaby as Laalah’s little body swung in her arms. The dim glow from the kitchen spilled into the room, softening the darkness. Her tears fell down her cheeks as she sang. As if she had a sea in her eyes. Despite her young age, she was a mature girl. She hardly cried in front of me or her father. Even when her father went to the other province for work, she said goodbye to him with a smile. But later that night, I heard her sobbing in her bed. She was not singing a lullaby but a song from Dawwod Sarkhosh. Her gentle voice echoed through the room:

Nights without songs will not remain, will not remain
the cruelty of time will not remain, will not remain

O merciless world, what have you done, what have you done
That little by little, Kabul is broken, broken

I thought my daughters' destiny would be far different from mine. I thought they could reach their twinkling stars in the capital city, but now everything had changed just in a blink. Now Kabul was in the hands of the Taliban. That long dark night passed but we lived through the nightmare everyday. Rumors spread about how Americans let everyone into their airplanes and take them to the United States. People were marching towards the Kabul International Airport. Our world was in chaos. It was as if Kabul itself was going to leave. The first day two young boys fell from the airplane and shattered into pieces. The news of the airport spread all over the world. Some empathized and others mocked us. Asking us to fight back instead of swinging from the plane's wings. But to fight who? Our own people? terrorists or the leaders that fled overnight? What could a citizen do without any support? Probably the one who suffered the most from this in our family was my husband. He was betrayed just like thousands of other soldiers who left the military bases with humiliation. Since that evening, his eyes were often fixed on something, staring blankly. Whenever I looked at him, I remembered an old saying, "the eyes are a window to the soul." I could see the emptiness he felt through his dull eyes. Who was he now? A soldier? or a toy they left behind after playing with it? I could not say a word to console him, my throat was blocked with heavy rocks of shock and horror. My mind was like an active volcano, erupting every moment, burning me with the lava of thoughts. Our lives changed overnight. The airport of Kabul and its surroundings were packed with people. No matter if they were in danger or not, they camped outside the airport, hoping to get out of there. Everyone remembered the first era of Taliban. When instead of love chaos and horror filled the houses. Poverty was the guest of their dinner table, and women were like walking dead. People feared that they would have to go through that again. Therefore, when they heard Americans were taking everyone with them, they all marched towards the international airport. Many got out but many died in the explosion that took place outside of there. I remember that evening hours before the explosion, when my husband came back home. That was the third time he was ordered to go to the airport, but failed to enter due to the crowd. His face was sunburned and dark circles had appeared around his eyes. He seemed much weaker. His exhausted and tired eyes stared at the red carpet, "I waited there for two days, but could not get in." He sat on the ground and began to dry his sweat from his forehead with a handkerchief he used to hide his face from the Taliban.

"What happened?"

"My American colleague told me to get away from the area because it was not safe." He stood up, his face became stiff when he touched his back. "I am going to get a shower." He almost whispered. I knew the story behind his back pain. It was the first and last gift he received as a military officer. He never told me about it directly. I heard it when he was telling his stories to his best friend: "I was in a tank, going to visit another base nearby with my three soldiers when suddenly a roadside bomb exploded and we all were thrown out of the tank on the hot sandy alley. I and another

soldier were the only ones who survived. We had our helmets on and that became our luck ticket. I was hospitalized in our military base for two days. They said my back bones were hurt. For days I could not move or even sit. “ He sighed, “ All the sacrifices for what? I lost my comrades, my friends but for what? ”

Fifteen days later, on the 30th of August the last US troops left Afghanistan. It was 12:00 pm or maybe 1:00 am, when we woke up to the sound of gun shots being fired continuously. By habit, I pulled the curtain up to see what was happening. The bullets flew like shooting stars in the dark sky of Kabul. Except these shooting stars were much different, they did not come to fulfill wishes, but to put an end to the dreams and hopes of thousands of Afghans that night. It was one month after that, that they closed the doors of schools for girls over the 6th grade. They divided the university classes with thick black curtains, so that men and women would not look at each other in the class. Later on they put a strict dress code for female university students: No bright colours are allowed, Wear all black, and cover your faces became the rules; however they realized that they had a problem with female existence in the society so they closed the doors of universities for women. When they announced that girls can not attend school or university, Afghan women marched on the streets, using their only power, their voice to stand against the Taliban. They protested several times but it always ended up in violence. Women were fogged, and beaten by the buttstock of their rifles. Many of the women were drugged into the police cars by force and disappeared. Rumours spread across the city and social media about women who committed suicide after they were released from the prison. Only God knows what they went through. Taliban were the same Taliban. The illiterate creatures with thick black beards wearing white traditional clothes, unlike their nature. Not long after that, they began to look for former government military officers and soldiers. They arrested them from their homes, beat them to death and demanded the guns that never existed. If they were *Pushtoon*, they would likely survive. But god forbid, if they were *Hazara* or *Tajik*, they could die. Many soldiers died like that, being drugged out of their houses at night and disappearing without a trace. Everyday we lived in horror, being pulled into the darkness without a way out. My husband went to Ghazni, his hometown to get a passport. The Taliban declared that everyone should get their passports from their hometown due to the crowdedness of Kabul's ministry of passport. Kabul was much like a war zone, everywhere you turned, bearded men with long shiny hair were marching on the sidewalks or sitting on the back of abandoned police cars, driving on the streets. Soon they started to search people's houses.

